

are colliding, in a sense, with the ecological system of the planet. We are now all of a sudden in the clichéd term, “the bull in the China shop”. We seem to be capable of doing casual damage without fully realising it or intending to do it.

Our footprint, in the metaphor of today, is larger and this new relationship comes from a combination of three factors. First of all, our absolute numbers have increased dramatically and continue to increase. Ten thousand generations of people lived on this earth before we reached an aggregate population of two billion, around the time my generation was born. In my lifetime, population has gone from a little over two billion to 6.7 billion. And my generation will see the number reach about nine billion..

Much is known now than even 20 years ago about why family size declines in nation after nation. They have done the analysis and proven that there are four factors, all of which must be present in some degree. The first and most important is the education of girls. The second, related to the first, is the empowerment of women. The third is the availability and culturally acceptable ways of fertility control and family planning. And the fourth, sometimes overlooked in the context of population dynamics, is an increase in child survival rates. The African leader Julius Nyerere said that the most powerful contraceptive in the world is the confidence on the part of parents that their children will survive. When girls are educated and women are empowered, they have the

means of participating effectively on the choice of family and have the confidence along with their partners that their children would survive, and can choose to have smaller families. The peer pressure of population on resources is a big part of the new reality that we have to observe and take account of.

The second factor after population is far more important. The scientific and technological revolution which is putting into the hand of human beings technologies thousands—even millions of times—more powerful than any our grandparents or great-grandparents could have imagined. Genetics is only one of the many fields where the secrets of the universe are being unlocked by the cleverest among us, giving us tools for good or ill and thankfully most are being used for good. But there are some side effects—and I don’t want to speak about genomics in this regard although the danger is there as well. But think of the powerful technologies for war. Alfred Nobel thought that the dynamite would be an instrument of peace and would lead to an end to conflict. It was used for other purposes.

Many of the technologies that we initially pursued to improve life turned out to have other uses as well. Some of the technologies now available to us for the exploitation of natural resources are being used with such abundance that the consequences have added up to a powerful destructive pattern. Let me just pick one example, ocean fisheries. The nets that people have used for thousands of years, harvest the bounty of the sea and leave the engines of its productivity intact. But it is now possible to pull nets that are 70 to 80-km-long, that dredge the bottom, vacuuming up every living thing in vast areas of the ocean. Ninety per cent of the beings are killed for nothing in order to make a profit on the 10 per cent that can be taken to market. This is insane. It is over time suicidal. And it is only one example.

We must find ways to become more conscious of the impact of these technologies. That leads to the third and final cause of this new relationship between humankind and the earth—our way of thinking, our consciousness. Because the combination of 6.7 billion people equipped on an average with technologies, which are millions of times more powerful than the previous generations ever had, produces this collusion, if we remain unaware of what we are doing.

So the challenge we face is to lift the level of our consciousness and to become more aware of what we are doing, who we are, what are our connections with each other and the choices that confront us in the human future.

Mahatma Gandhi, India’s gift to the world and history, felt that perhaps the most powerful force for constructive change was Satyagraha, the truth force. The truth about climate crisis is the key to lifting our consciousness about who we are. The challenges we face, the ones that I mentioned, face India and the world as a whole, and they sometimes masquerade as political problems. And we are tempted to feel frustrated, confused, uncertain and be daunted by extreme difficulties of even attempting to solve them. Our real challenge is to see them in their true light not as political problems but as imperatives. There have been

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